Grounding Exercises: Data Visceralization for Advocacy & Awareness of Depersonalization and Derealization

Dwyer, Kaylen
kaylendwyer@gmail.com
Tufts University, United States of America

"Grounding Exercises" is a series of artistic representations and data visceralizations that seeks to translate the intangible and often alienating experiences of depersonalization and derealization (DPDR) into embodied, sensory forms. Defined by profound feelings of detachment from oneself or surroundings, DPDR impacts up to 50% of people transiently and 1–2% of people chronically, yet it remains under-researched and widely misunderstood (Medford 2012). The stigma surrounding DPDR, combined with the difficulty of articulating its symptoms, can lead to feelings of isolation and alienation. This project draws on the language and experiences shared by individuals in the r/dpdr subreddit, an online community where users connect over their shared struggles. Through text analysis and data visceralization, "Grounding Exercises" advocates for greater understanding and awareness of DPDR.

Depersonalization and derealization are characterized by profound feelings of unreality or detachment from the self or surroundings in the absence of psychosis. Depersonalization (DP) impacts one's inner world—thoughts, feelings, sensations, body, or sense of agency—while derealization (DR) alters the perception of the external world, often described as feeling "unreal," "dreamlike," or "foggy" (APA, 2013). For those with chronic DPDR, the disorder functions as both a survival mechanism in response to trauma and a source of persistent suffering, as described by Simeon and Abugel (2006), replacing horrific emotions with "a real fear of losing their mind." The difficulty in describing DPDR experiences is a central feature of the disorder, one that compounds its alienating effects. Yet, online spaces like the r/dpdr subreddit have emerged as critical platforms where sufferers share their stories, using metaphor-rich language to articulate what traditional diagnostic categories often fail to capture. Posts frequently begin with the question, "Does anyone else experience this?"—a question that underscores both the isolation of the disorder and the collective need for recognition and understanding.

The project begins by analyzing these accounts using Named Entity Recognition (NER) with GLiNER SpaCy to identify references to body parts and related symptoms. The body is often central to the DPDR experience, serving as both a source of distress—due to the sense of disconnection and estrangement from the self—and also as the primary means of grounding and reconnecting to the self. By examining these bodily descriptions and their surrounding context, the analysis illuminates how sufferers conceptualize their experiences in relation to (dis)embodiment. This project builds on the work of Dilkes (2024), who analyzed metaphors in DPDR online forums; D'Ignazio and Klein (2020) who call for embodied and affective approaches to data analysis; and Kelly Dobson's care-centered methods for data visceralization.

The goal of "Grounding Exercises" is to transform these insights into visceral, multi-sensory representations that foster empathy, understanding, and help to communicate the unspeakable experiences of DPDR. While traditional data visualizations can contribute to dehumanization and disembodiment of human subjects, this project embraces the principles of feminist, care-centered data visceralization to create representations that engage viewers physically and emotionally. Multiple installations are planned which will include interactive sculptures that combine light, sound, touch, and interaction. The first installation will visualize co-occurrences of body parts and symptoms using electroluminescent wires to represent connections between body parts mentioned in the subreddit with sound conveying the emotional tones of users' experiences.

Ethical considerations are central to this project, as it draws from a vulnerable online community. Posts from deleted accounts have been excluded, usernames have been anonymized, and direct quotes are paraphrased in shared materials. Additionally, synthetic data—generated to approximate the linguistic patterns of the original dataset—is used in publicly accessible code and interactive modules to protect user privacy. These measures align with broader concerns about the ethical use of big data, particularly in research involving marginalized communities.

The advocacy potential of "Grounding Exercises" lies in its ability to bridge gaps in understanding between DPDR sufferers and the broader public, including clinicians, friends, and family. As a condition that is largely ignored, public engagement through this project could raise awareness and interest among researchers and clinicians. While the language used by those with DPDR

is vivid and metaphorically rich, its impact is often lost on those unfamiliar with the disorder. By translating these experiences into tangible, sensory forms, the project makes the invisible visible, fostering a deeper connection between those who suffer and those who seek to understand.

"Grounding Exercises" also contributes to the growing discourse around embodied knowledge in the digital humanities. Harmony Bench and Kate Elswit (2023) emphasize the importance of engaging with the physicality of the body in data representation, resisting the tendency to reduce the body to metaphor or abstraction. This project takes up their call by centering the body both as a site of inquiry and as a medium for advocacy. Through the use of light, sound, and touch, the visceralizations aim to communicate the embodied realities of DPDR while challenging traditional notions of what data representation can and should accomplish.

In the context of the conference theme of "advocacy and impact," "Grounding Exercises" exemplifies how data-driven projects can extend beyond academic analysis to create meaningful social change. By raising awareness of DPDR and fostering empathy for those who suffer, the project contributes to broader efforts to destigmatize mental health conditions and advocate for more comprehensive research and treatment.

As the project evolves, it will continue to explore the intersections of advocacy, art, and data, creating a series of visceralizations that push the boundaries of traditional data representation. By centering the voices and experiences of DPDR sufferers, "Grounding Exercises" not only amplifies their call for recognition but also serves as a testament to the power of community, connection, and shared understanding.

Bibliography

American Psychiatric Association (2013): *Diagnostic and statistical manual of mental disorders: DSM-5* (Fifth edition). American Psychiatric Association.

Bench, Harmony / Elswit, Kate (2023): "The Body is Not (Only) A Metaphor: Rethinking Embodiment in DH", in: Gold, Matthew K. / Klein, Lauren F. (eds.): *Debates in the Digital Humanities* . University of Minnesota Press. <https://dhdebates.gc.cuny.edu/read/f3f87448-138c 4d19-8ff8-b06acf40ddd1/section/6224c2b2-4b60-4315-82e7-84900b52fd1e#en92>.

Dilkes , Jane (2024): "Metaphor use in depersonalization/derealization", in: *Language and Cognition* 16, 2: 329–352. DOI: 10.1017/langcog.2023.39.

D'Ignazio, Catherine / Klein, Lauren. F. (2020): *Data Feminism* . The MIT Press. DOI: 10.7551/mitpress/11805.001.0001.

Medford, Nick (2012): "Emotion and the Unreal Self: Depersonalization Disorder and De-Affectualization", in: *Emotion Review* 4, 2: 139–144. DOI: 10.1177/1754073911430135.

Simeon, Daphne / Abugel, Jeffrey (2006): *Feeling Unreal: Depersonalization Disorder and the Loss of the Self* . Oxford University Press.